Was it all for nothing? He had promised that the Russian women would survive if they remained here under Josef's care. She had to confront him and learn the truth. She would not uphold her end of the agreement if he had broken his.

Her blood thumped in her ears as she trudged through the town. With each step she took, she heard the guard's words repeating in her head—they were sent away—and with it the shuddering possibility that they had been sent to death camps. She reached the building across from the church, pulled the door open and took the steps up to the Gestapo office. She'd never been here in the middle of the day, but she'd already decided that if he wasn't here, she'd wait, refusing to leave until he returned.

She heard the crackling of the fire as she approached the open door. How was it fair that Nadiya had died and the other women were in a truck being transported to a camp. Yet he sat in his warm office. She stepped inside. He looked up.

"Rose." He lifted one eyebrow. "What are you doing here at this hour?"

"Where are the Russian women?" Her voice trembled. "We had a deal. You've—"

"I've kept them safe."

"Tell me where they are."

"Trust me."

Feeling bolder, she lowered her voice. "Bring them back." She reached for the ring in her pocket and held it in the air. "Or our deal is off."

"You don't know what you're talking about." A faint tic in his jaw. "If they're here when the Soviet troops arrive, which will be very soon, then they won't survive."

He peddled lies; his words were a slap in the face, a cruel reminder of the twisted reality he lived in. "Why would they kill their people?"

"Russia is an old military power. It understands the true nature of war."

"What does that mean?"

He dropped the pen and leaned back in his chair. "The Soviet army doesn't care about its own people. They fight with blind rage, destroying all in their path. Do you think it matters how many of their own die?" He wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. "That's how they took Poland, Yugoslavia and now East Prussia and Silesia from us."

Rose looked at the window. Long shadows fell across the floor as the